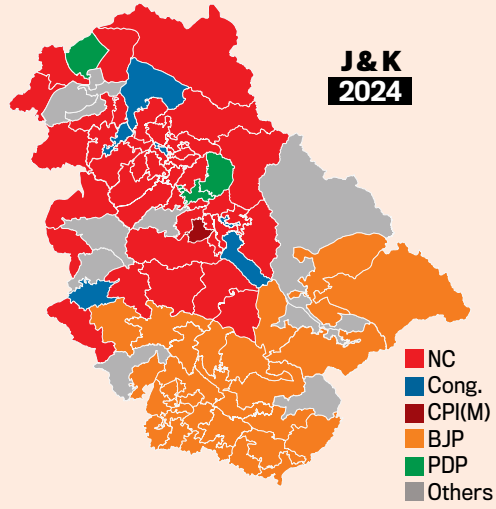
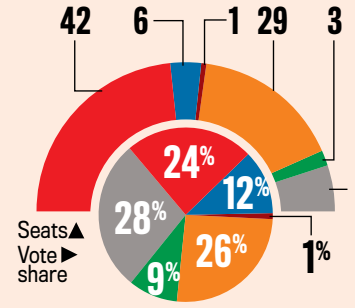
CHEER FOR TEAM I.N.D.I.A

The alliance won 48 out of J&K's 90 seats. The NC won 35 in Kashmir, 7 in Jammu; the Congress 1 in Jammu, 5 in Kashmir. The BJP won all its 29 seats in Jammu



Total seats: 90
Majority mark: 46*

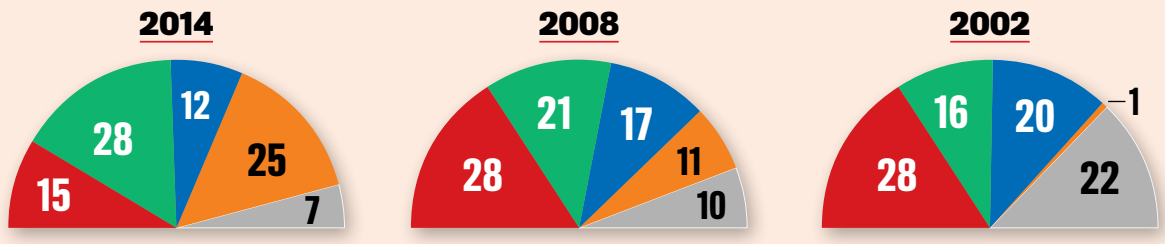
ASSEMBLY 2024



Rises to 48 if five members are nominated

HOW J&K VOTED IN THE PAST

Total seats: 87*



*Includes four assembly seats in Ladakh

Set to be chief minister once again, Omar is acutely aware that his powers will be greatly curtailed this time around, especially since the Modi government had on August 5, 2019, abrogated Article 370, taking away the extraordinary autonomy J&K enjoyed, and reducing its status from a state to a Union Territory, apart from bifurcating Ladakh from it. More recently, the Centre amended the rules of the 'Transaction of Business of the Government of Union Territory of Jammu and Kashmir' to ensure that Lieutenant Governor Manoj Sinha had even more administrative and legal powers. The new changes bestow on the LG the power to transfer IAS and IPS officers, control J&K Police and law and order, and have a say in the appointment of judicial officers, including the advocate general. The Anti-Corruption Bureau, prosecution matters and prisons will also be now under his ambit. In fact, before the election was announced, Omar had maintained that he would not contest as he had no intention of, as he put it, "waiting outside the LG's office to sign a file" even for the appointment of a peon. The other reason was that Omar had failed to win a parliamentary seat in the Lok Sabha election in May 2024, losing to the jailed Engineer Rashid, an Independent candidate, in the Baramulla constituency. But he relented after his JKNC colleagues told him that if the party was planning to participate in the election, his refusal to contest would doom their chances.

POLARISED VERDICT

What makes Omar's job even tougher is that the election has thrown up a deeply polarised verdict between the Kashmir Valley and Jammu. While the JKNC's individual tally of 42 included seven seats in the Jammu region, these were in the Muslim-dominated constituencies. The alliance was let down by the Congress, which won only one seat, also in a Muslim-dominated constituency, despite contesting 29 out of Jammu's 43 seats. Its five other wins came from seats in the Muslim-majority Valley. And even though the BJP did not win any of the 19 seats it contested in the Valley, it won all the Hindu-dominated seats in Jammu with a tally of 29. This means Omar will have to strive hard to win the confidence of Jammu where a majority of the Hindu community lives.

Haseeb A. Drabu, a former J&K finance minister, believes that the election results have only added to the fissures between Jammu and Kashmir. As he puts it, "The two regions now share little else than a troubled past, having nothing in common: geographically, linguistically, culturally, ethnically, economically and in terms of religion." Omar knows the gravity of that divide and is determined that his government will not just be a JKNC-Congress one but a dispensation that represents all sections of society. As he said, "The votes did not split in Kashmir and Jammu mountains. People